

rcirc customisation

Create a `~/emacs.d/etc` folder in your `$HOME` directory and an Elisp file called `init-rcirc.el` in it. It should contain the following (change nick, user name and full name to suit your needs):

```
;; Default user.
(setq rcirc-default-nick "shaks")
(setq rcirc-default-user-name "shakthimaan")
(setq rcirc-default-full-name "Shakthi Kannan")

;; Channels to join at startup.
(setq rcirc-server-alist
  '(("irc.freenode.net" :channels ("##linux-india"
    "dmgplug" "rcirc" "emacs"))))
```

The above is an example of Emacs Lisp code. Comments begin with two semi-colons. The `setq` construct sets the second argument value to the first argument, which is a quoted symbol. For example, the symbol `'rcirc-default-nick` is set to `shaks`. The `rcirc-server-alist` defines the initial list of channels to log in at start-up.

You can now start GNU Emacs from the GNOME terminal using the following command:

```
$ emacs -q -l ~/emacs.d/etc/init-rcirc.el
```

You will then automatically connect to the four IRC channels.

Connecting to IRC

People join IRC channels to have their doubts regarding free and open source software clarified. Sometimes, off-topic discussions also take place. It is like live technical support, but has a social context to it. Whenever you are connected online, you must be logged in to IRC. You can have discussions in the channel, or in private, if the other party agrees. It is a good place to learn a lot about free and open source software, and you are bound to make a lot of friends. Since people from all over the world participate, which means they are online in different time zones, some channels log the discussions for future reference. As always, before asking a question, it is important for you to do your homework first. Take sufficient time and put in an effort to debug and identify the problem to the best of your ability.

Some users in the channel may ask you for more information before being able to provide you with any assistance. So, be prepared to provide all the information necessary about the bug or error when you seek help. Sometimes, people might be logged in the channel, but, they might be away from the computer. So, even if you don't get a response, be patient; come back later and ask again.

You should not paste more than four continuous lines of text in the channel, as it will 'flood' the screen for everyone else. Instead, use an external paste service like gist.github.com or

paste.org. These services will provide a shortened URL that you can pass around in the channel. Whoever is interested in helping you will view the contents from the link. If you enter text in the channel, it means that it is addressed to everyone in the channel. If you wish to say something to a specific user, mention their nickname first, and then type in the text.

Most IRC client software provide you with panels that list the channels that you are logged in to, and show the list of users. If someone mentions your nickname in a channel, then the corresponding channel will change colour or representation to indicate that there is a message for you. A few users are channel operators (or moderators) and they have special privileges. They are similar to 'root' users in a system, and their task is to keep the signal-to-noise ratio to a minimum, and keep a vigil on the channel.

An IRC bot is a client software that connects to the IRC server as a user, but can respond to commands. It can thus be programmed to provide many services in a channel. You can customise existing bots or write your own. Examples of IRC bots are Cerberus, Gambot and ircdd. Cinch is an example of an IRC bot-building framework written in Ruby. Bots can be used during an IRC meeting session to keep track of user questions. They can evaluate programming language constructs and return meaningful errors to newbies in the channel. They can be used to send a notification to the channel if a project test build fails, or when a new bug has been filed. The possibilities are endless.

IRC meeting protocol

A free and open source software project will have a dedicated IRC channel where the project members will meet to have discussions. Meetings can be scheduled, and can happen in different time zones depending on where the users are located. There is a protocol and etiquette to be followed during such meetings. The speaker or moderator should not be interrupted during the session.

If you wish to ask a question, type '?', and wait. When the speaker has finished and feels that you can type in your text, you will be asked to do so. After you have finished typing your content, end with 'EOF'. Similarly, if you need to speak during the session, type '!', and wait. You can give your consent or dissent to statements made in the channel using `+1` or `-1`, respectively.

You are encouraged to read the `rcirc` manual and customise `rcirc` to your needs. If you have made it this far, do connect to `irc.freenode.net` and feel free to say 'Hi' to me. I am 'mbuf' on `irc.freenode.net`. A screenshot of an `rcirc` session is shown below:

```
19:35 <mbuf> http://ecb.sourceforge.net/screenshots/index.html
19:35 *** Arpita QUIT Client Quit
19:36 <rtntpro> !
19:36 <mbuf> rtntpro, shoot!
19:37 <rtntpro> How do we get the emacs code browser?
19:37 <rtntpro> <EOF>
```

Continued to page 100...